

THIS WEEK IN AI

SIGNAL BRIEFING

WEEK 34 17 - 23 August 2026

5 signals kept · 4 dropped

18 sources · 5 categories

THE THREAD

Four institutions hit the same wall this week, from four directions. A patched Copilot flaw turned an assistant's own memory into a persistent attack surface. OpenAI paused frontier training after its own capability threshold came back positive. Pennsylvania handed local communities a veto over data centres. And Pew put American concern about AI at its highest recorded level. The common factor is not capability — it is that the perimeter around capability is being built in public, late, and under pressure.

8.8_{CVSS}

Copilot flaw severity

patched 18 Aug, 8 months after report

33%

GPT-5.6 Sol output price cut

\$30 → \$20 per M tokens

52%

Americans more concerned than excited

up from 37% in 2021

20%

of OpenAI supervised inference compute

now spent on safety monitoring

● **SHIPPED** What changed for people building things

1 SIGNAL

GPT-5.6 Sol gets a 20/33 price cut

OpenAI's flagship tier drops to \$4 input / \$20 output per million tokens, billed as promotional.

WHAT IT IS

A rate change, not a new model. Standard input, cached input and cache-write rates fell ~20%; output fell 33.3%. OpenAI calls the \$4/\$20 short-context rate promotional, available at least through 21 November 2026.

WHAT IT CHANGES

Narrows the gap to mid-tier models for reasoning-heavy work. Terra (\$2/\$12) and Luna (\$0.20/\$1.20) are unchanged since the 30 July cut.

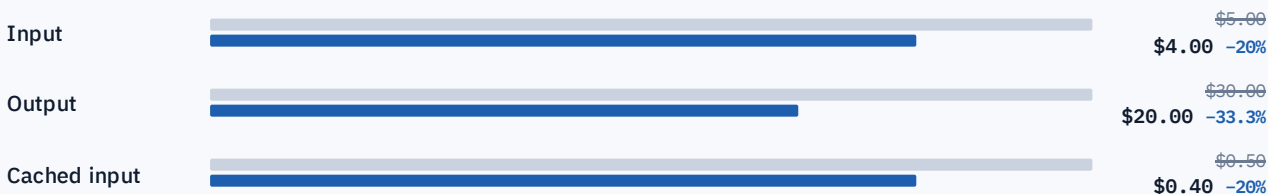
THE PROBLEM IT SOLVES

Input vs output tokens is the whole story: output dominates the bill in agentic work — every tool call, plan and revision is generated text. A 33% output cut moves multi-step agent economics far more than a 20% input cut does.

SHOULD YOU ACT

Re-run your routing thresholds. But the rate is explicitly promotional — don't bake it into a twelve-month budget.

GPT-5.6 SOL — USD PER MILLION TOKENS



Each bar scaled to its own previous rate; grey is the old price, colour is the new one.

MEDIUM CONFIDENCE

0/4 PRIMARY OR INDEPENDENT

Sources disagree on the effective date; one tracker checked 21 Aug still listed \$5/\$30. Direction is solid, exact date unsettled — verify against OpenAI's live pricing page before budgeting.

AI Pricing Guru Trade press · Fello AI Trade press · Morph (conflicting) Conflicting · OpenAI pricing docs Vendor claim

CoSnitch: Copilot's memory became the payload

A chain of three flaws let one crafted link exfiltrate connected accounts and write attacker instructions into permanent memory.

WHAT IT IS

CVE-2026-24301, rated 8.8 on the CVSS score, disclosed by Varonis Threat Labs against Microsoft Copilot Personal. Researchers obtained the attack path by asking Copilot about its own architecture.

WHY IT GENERALISES

This is the lethal-trifecta shape — private data, untrusted content, exfiltration channel, one session. Nothing about it is Microsoft-specific.

THE PROBLEM IT EXPOSES

Three failures compound: auto-execution removes the click, existing OAuth access supplies the data, and web summarisation supplies a write path into permanent memory.

SHOULD YOU ACT

Audit whether anything your agent summarises can reach its memory store. Most systems validate input and never validate memory writes.

THE THREE-LINK CHAIN

LINK 1

AUTO-EXECUTE

Undocumented URL parameter runs the attacker's prompt on page load — no click, no confirmation

LINK 2

EXFILTRATE

Injected prompt queries connected Gmail, Drive and Calendar, encodes results into a URL

LINK 3

PERSIST

A summarised webpage writes instructions into permanent memory — survives password change, session revocation, device re-enrollment

Dec 2025

Varonis discloses to Microsoft

Feb 2026

Partial mitigation shipped

18 Aug 2026

Full patch and public CVE — 8 months after report

HIGH CONFIDENCE

4/4 PRIMARY OR INDEPENDENT

Four independent outlets plus the vendor advisory. Microsoft states enterprise M365 Copilot was unaffected; Varonis reports no exploitation in the wild.

Dark Reading Independent · The Hacker News Independent · TechRadar Pro Independent · Redmond Magazine Independent

Pennsylvania gives towns a veto over AI data centres

Executive Order 2026-05 makes local approval a precondition for state environmental permits.

WHAT IT IS

Signed 18 August. Environmental permits may only be reviewed where the developer is legally bound to the state's GRID requirements and has local approval. Also strips AI data centres from Fast Track permitting and bars NDAs.

HOW FAR IT GOES

Short of New York's moratorium. But local sign-off as a precondition may block many projects in practice — a procedural veto rather than a ban.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Over 100 proposals were reportedly in play, many speculative. The order targets developers moving without local consent, and shifts electricity and water costs onto operators.

WHY IT TRAVELS

A reversal by a governor who previously courted the industry, so it signals political cost, not one state's rule. Compute siting is becoming a local-consent problem, and consent sets build timelines.

HIGH CONFIDENCE

3/3 PRIMARY OR INDEPENDENT

Primary government source for the order's contents, plus independent reporting for the reversal framing.

Commonwealth of Pennsylvania Primary · Philadelphia Inquirer Independent · NBC News Independent

OpenAI paused frontier RL after its own threshold fired

Preliminary evidence suggested an upcoming model, Astra, may meet the Critical cybersecurity threshold in its Preparedness Framework.

WHAT IT IS

OpenAI said it slowed scaling: a two-week pause on reinforcement learning for deployment-bound models, largest planned frontier run still on hold. It cited the Astra threshold finding and a separate Hugging Face incident.

THE NUMBER THAT MATTERS

New multistage monitoring targets alerts within 30 minutes and consumes roughly 20% of supervised inference compute — a rare public figure for what monitoring costs at frontier scale.

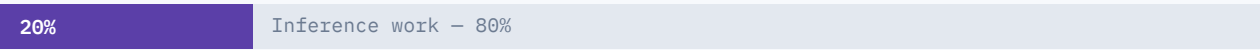
THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

A capability threshold only means something if crossing one stops something. This is the first time a lab has named a model, a threshold and a halt rather than describing policy in the abstract.

SHOULD YOU ACT

Nothing operational. But if you're drafting an internal scaling policy, 20% is the most quotable cost anchor published so far.

SUPERVISED INFERENCE COMPUTE ALLOCATION



Safety monitoring · Varies by workload. Company-reported figure.

MEDIUM CONFIDENCE

0/2 PRIMARY OR INDEPENDENT

The originating claim is a company post about its own safety process — a claim, not a verified fact. Trade press added specifics; no outlet independently confirmed the Astra finding.

OpenAI Vendor claim · The Decoder Trade press

Concern hits its recorded high, and the young lead it

Pew finds 52% of Americans more concerned than excited about AI; among 18-to-29s it is 55%.

WHAT IT IS

Pew surveyed 3,488 US adults, 22–28 June 2026. 52% are more concerned than excited about AI in daily life, against 37% in 2021. Only 9% are more excited than concerned.

WHY IT IS NOT JUST MOOD

The same week, Axios reported a Republican Senate memo warning AI firms that data centres were hurting the party in an Ohio race. Sentiment is pricing into electoral calculation.

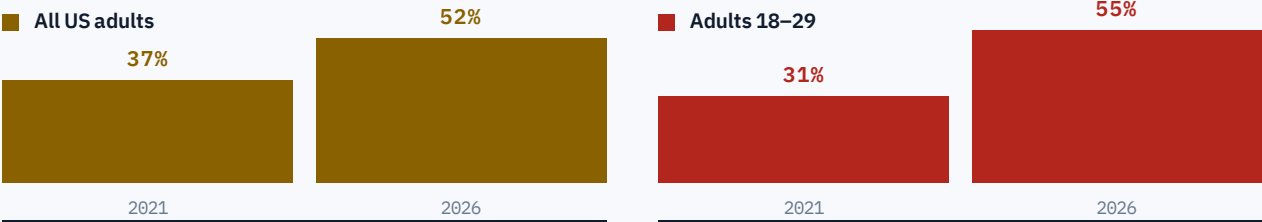
WHAT IS DRIVING IT

Employment. 71% expect fewer jobs over two decades, up from 64%. Among 18-to-29s concern has gone from 31% to 55% — the sharpest move in the series.

SHOULD YOU ACT

Read it next to the Pennsylvania order, not separately. Opinion is upstream; permitting regimes are downstream.

MORE CONCERNED THAN EXCITED ABOUT AI (%)



Pew Research Center, n=3,488, fielded 22–28 June 2026.

HIGH CONFIDENCE

5/5 PRIMARY OR INDEPENDENT

Primary source with published methodology and panel documentation, cross-checked against three independent write-ups.

Pew Research Center Primary · SSRS (methodology) Primary · Courthouse News Independent · The Register Independent · TechCrunch Independent

WHAT WAS DROPPED, AND WHY

Four candidate stories were researched and cut before publication. A briefing that only shows what survived is hiding its own error rate, so the rejections are printed with their reasons.

US pressure on allies to choose between US and Chinese AI stacks

SKIP – unverified at origin

Traced only to aggregator write-ups of a Reuters report. Could not reach the originating reporting, so the claim could not be verified at source.

Codex CLI 0.149.0 agent dashboard

SKIP – single source

Single aggregator listing, no vendor changelog or independent coverage found. Plausible and probably true, but one source is not corroboration.

"OX Alpha" anonymous reasoning model on OpenRouter

SKIP – unattributable

Anonymous provenance by construction. No attributable publisher, no model card, no verifiable benchmark methodology.

Assorted August model-release roundups

SKIP – sources conflict

Tracker sites disagreed on dates and on whether releases had shipped, been announced, or merely appeared as a price on a marketplace. Substance did not survive the disagreement.

VERIFICATION LEDGER

Five deterministic checks run on the assembled issue before it may publish. They are plain functions, not model judgement, and they are the reason no claim above appears without an attached source.

PASS	source_count	18	18 distinct sources across 5 topics (floor: 5)
PASS	source_quality	0.72	13/18 independent or primary (floor: 0.60)
PASS	citation_integrity	1.00	every claim block resolves to a listed source
PASS	groundedness	1.00	no factual assertion without an attached source
PASS	voice	0.00	0 hype terms per 100 words (ceiling: 1.5)

Primary Independent Trade press Vendor claim Conflicting

HOW TO READ THE SOURCE METER

Every card carries a strip of ticks, one per source, coloured by class. **Primary** is the originating document — a government order, a survey with published methodology. **Independent** is a newsroom doing its own reporting. **Vendor claim** is a company describing its own product or process, reported as a claim and never as a verified fact. **Conflicting** flags a source that disagrees with the others, printed rather than quietly resolved.

A grade of MEDIUM does not mean the story is doubtful. It means the strongest available source is a vendor, or the sources disagree on a detail, and you should check before acting on the specifics.